



tion is still run by us and should not allow the cops to rejoice in a fashion as if the Trinamool has already come to power. We should go with folded hands to the people and apologise," he says. CPI Minister Nandagopal Bhattacharya joins the chorus: "The CPI(M) must start treating human beings as men and women and not cattle. They won't give an inch to others—from minister to peon, everyone has to be a CPI(M) man."

Not much is being said about the first decade when the Left's governance was excellent and rural land reform was a beacon for the nation. But the disillusionment and the ensuing cadre raj led many party diehard top leaders to leave. The most notable among them was CPI(M) Central Committee member Saifuddin Choudhury who formed the Party of Democratic Socialism in 2000. "The CPI(M) still believes in the Stalinist dogma of force. Villages were being ruled by partymen who had no touch

with our party line. This absolutism became the CPI(M)'s main enemy within. The political future of the state is calamitous. There is no alternative anywhere," Choudhury says.

Filmmaker Aparna Sen, who took to the streets soon after the Nandigram firing, says the CPI(M)'s arrogance was the direct result of 32 years of rule. "This is complacency at its worst. For the last two decades, it had become a regional party for endowment. But you cannot fool all the people all the time," says Sen. Academician and political commentator Ratan Khasnabish says, "Polls told us that there were over 45 per cent of opposition votes but the opposition was nowhere. Inside the party, it was anarchy. The villages understood that the Reds were hardly saviours and ditched them." Khasnabish believes Bhattacharya misinterpreted Deng

Xiaoping's reforms. "You cannot become friends of the Tatas and Birlas overnight after raising slogans against them for decades. Basu talked of development. Bhattacharya loves industrialisation. Look where this has led him to," he says.

Pradyot Guha, former Congress general secretary and Pranab Mukherjee's trusted aide who has been with the party for four decades, believes that the CPI(M) game is over. "It's a party with a negative mindset. There's a way to explain, as Pranab says, 'Why couldn't a party, which was born around Independence, not go beyond three states while the BJP, formed years later, is now a national party?'" he asks.

But it's Mamata who has the last word. "The CPI(M) is a party of liars and terrorists. The people have given their verdict. Lalgurha has now exposed them in the worst possible manner. I do not think that they will have a place to hide for much longer," she says. With nowhere to run and nowhere left to hide, the CPI(M) may well start counting the nails in its coffin in West Bengal. ■

Buddhadeb was considering similar state action.